Local Hub

How to Prevent Costly Water Damage at Home

A practical guide to the leaks you can stop, the checks worth doing, and what to do in the first hour if water gets in.

A free guide from the Local Hub network · mylocal-hub.com

Introduction

Water damage is one of the most common — and most expensive — problems a household can face. It rarely announces itself. A small drip behind a wall, a clogged gutter, or a worn hose can go unnoticed for weeks, and by the time you see a stain the damage underneath is often well established.

The good news: most water damage is preventable, and the habits that prevent it are simple. This guide is written for homeowners and renters, with no technical background needed. It will help you:

- **Understand** where household water damage usually starts.
- **Check** your home with a short monthly and seasonal routine.
- **React** quickly and calmly during the first hour after a leak.
- **Decide** when it is time to call a professional.
- **Prepare** for a conversation with your insurer.

> **Why speed matters**
>
> Water spreads further and faster than most people expect. Porous materials such as drywall, insulation, carpet and wood can start to absorb moisture right away, and mould can begin to grow within a day or two in damp conditions. Acting early usually means a smaller job — and a smaller bill.

How to use this guide

Read pages 3–4 once to learn the common trouble spots. Print or save the checklist on page 5 and put a repeating reminder in your calendar. Keep page 6 somewhere easy to find — on the fridge or in your phone — so you know exactly what to do if water appears at 2 a.m.

> **A note on this guide**
>
> This is general information to help you be prepared. It is not a substitute for advice from a licensed plumber, electrician, restoration professional or your insurance provider, who can assess your specific situation.

The top causes of water damage

Five areas account for a large share of household water problems. Know them, and you know where to look.

1 Pipes and plumbing fittings

Supply lines, drain lines and the joints between them wear out. Corrosion, loose fittings, high water pressure and age all contribute. Leaks under sinks, behind toilets and inside walls are the classic hidden culprits.

Warning signs: water stains on ceilings or walls, bubbling paint, a musty smell, the sound of running water when nothing is on, or a water bill that creeps up for no clear reason.

Prevent it: look under sinks monthly, know where your main shut-off valve is, and ask a plumber to check pressure if fixtures seem noisy or hoses wear quickly.

2 Appliances and their hoses

Washing machines, dishwashers, refrigerators with ice makers, water heaters and humidifiers all connect to your water supply. Rubber hoses harden and crack over time, and a failed hose or tank can release a lot of water quickly.

Warning signs: bulging or cracked hoses, rust or moisture around connections, puddles near the appliance, or a water heater that is leaking or corroded at the base.

Prevent it: inspect hoses at least twice a year, consider braided stainless-steel replacements, leave a little space behind appliances so you can see the connections, and replace hoses and water heaters on the manufacturer's suggested schedule.

3 The roof, gutters and exterior

Missing or lifted shingles, damaged flashing around chimneys and vents, and clogged gutters let rain and melting snow find a way in. Water that pools against the foundation can also seep into basements.

Warning signs: stains on upper-floor ceilings, damp attic insulation, shingles in the yard after a storm, overflowing gutters, or downspouts that dump water next to the house.

Prevent it: clear gutters in spring and fall, point downspouts well away from the foundation, and have the roof looked at after severe weather.

The top causes, continued

4 Sump pumps and basement drainage

If your home has a sump pump, it is your basement's last line of defence — and it tends to fail exactly when it is needed, during heavy rain or a fast thaw. Power cuts, stuck float switches and clogged inlets are common reasons.

Warning signs: a pump that runs constantly or not at all, strange noises, standing water in the pit, or damp patches on basement floors and walls.

Prevent it: every few months, pour a bucket of water into the pit to confirm the pump switches on and empties it. Clean the pit, check the discharge pipe is clear, and ask about a battery backup so it keeps working in a power outage. Floor drains should be clear too.

5 Frozen pipes

When water freezes it expands, and a pipe that freezes can split. The damage often shows up only when the ice thaws and water pours out. Pipes in exterior walls, attics, garages, crawl spaces and under sinks on cold walls are most at risk.

Warning signs: a trickle or no water from a tap during very cold weather, frost on visible pipes, or odd smells from drains.

Prevent it: insulate exposed pipes, disconnect and drain outdoor hoses before winter, shut off and drain outdoor taps if you can, and let cabinet doors under sinks on exterior walls stay open on the coldest nights. Keep the heating on if you are away — do not set it too low.

If a pipe is frozen but not yet burst

Open the tap slightly, and gently warm the area with a hair dryer or warm towels, working from the tap back towards the frozen section. Never use an open flame. If you cannot find the frozen section, cannot reach it, or the pipe has already split, shut off the water at the main valve and call a plumber.

Other things worth watching

Failed caulking around tubs and showers, overflowing toilets, window and door seals, ice dams on the roof edge, and plant pots or irrigation lines close to the foundation can all quietly let water in.

Your monthly and seasonal checklist

Fifteen minutes a month beats a weekend of cleanup. Print this page or save it to your phone.

Every month

- ☐ Look under kitchen and bathroom sinks for drips, moisture or swelling in the cabinet base.
- ☐ Check around toilets, tubs and showers for soft spots, discoloured caulk or water on the floor.
- ☐ Glance at the washing machine and dishwasher hoses and the area around the water heater.
- ☐ Look at the ceiling and the basement walls for new stains or a damp smell.
- ☐ Read your water meter before and after a couple of hours when no water is used — if it moves, there may be a leak.

Spring

- Clean gutters and check downspouts drain away from the house.
- Test the sump pump with a bucket of water.
- Inspect the roof from the ground for lifted or missing shingles.
- Reconnect and check outdoor hoses and taps for leaks.
- Check basement walls and floors after the thaw.

Summer

- Inspect appliance hoses and replace any that look worn.
- Check the grading around the foundation — soil should slope away.
- Look at caulking around tubs, showers and windows.
- Flush the water heater if the manufacturer recommends it.
- Make sure floor drains are clear before storm season.

Fall

- Clean gutters again once leaves have dropped.
- Disconnect and drain outdoor hoses; drain outdoor taps if possible.
- Insulate exposed pipes in garages, attics and crawl spaces.
- Check window, door and vent seals before winter.
- Locate your main shut-off valve and make sure it turns.

Winter

- Keep the heat on, even if you are away.
- Open cabinet doors on exterior walls during cold snaps.
- Let a tap drip slightly on the coldest nights.
- Clear snow and ice away from the foundation and vents.
- Check the attic for damp insulation or ice dams.

The first hour after a leak

Stay calm and work through these steps in order. Your safety comes first, then the water, then the paperwork.

Safety first

If water is near electrical outlets, appliances, a fuse box or light fixtures, or the ceiling is sagging or bulging, stay out of the area, switch off power at the breaker only if you can reach it safely and without stepping in water, and call a professional. When in doubt, leave and call for help.

1. **Stop the water.** Close the shut-off valve for the leaking fixture or appliance, or the main water valve for the house. Know where this valve is *before* you need it.
2. **Make it safe.** Keep people and pets away from standing water and wet electrics. If you suspect the water has reached outlets or the panel, do not touch them.
3. **Take photos and video.** Before moving anything, record the source, the affected areas and damaged belongings. Wide shots and close-ups both help.
4. **Limit the spread.** Mop or soak up standing water with towels, a wet/dry vacuum or buckets. Lift small items, rugs and furniture legs off wet floors; place foil or plastic under furniture feet.
5. **Move valuables.** Take electronics, documents, photos and anything irreplaceable to a dry room. Leave heavy or fixed items where they are.
6. **Start air movement.** If it is safe, open windows and run fans to help drying. Avoid using household vacuums on large amounts of water.
7. **Call for help.** Contact a licensed plumber if a pipe or fixture needs repair, and a restoration company if there is more than a small puddle. Then contact your insurance provider (see page 8).

Don’t

Don’t use heat to rush-dry materials, don’t throw away damaged items until you have documented them, and don’t assume the problem is over once the surface looks dry — moisture can remain inside walls and floors.

When to call a pro

Many small drips are fine for a confident DIYer. Some situations are not. Here is a simple way to tell.

Reasonable to handle yourself

- A small drip from a tap or an accessible under-sink connection
- Replacing a washing machine hose with the water off
- Mopping up a small spill or overflow
- Clearing a simple slow drain
- Cleaning gutters at ground level or from a safe, stable ladder

Call a professional

- Water you can't stop, or a main shut-off that won't turn
- Water near electrics, or a sagging or bulging ceiling
- A burst or frozen pipe inside a wall or ceiling
- Sewage or grey water backing up
- A leaking or damaged water heater
- Water that has been present more than a day or two, or any visible mould
- Roof leaks, or anything that needs working at height

Which kind of pro?

- **Plumber** — finds and fixes the source: pipes, fixtures, hoses, water heaters, sump pumps and drains.
- **Water-damage restoration company** — removes water, dries the structure with professional equipment, and handles cleanup and mould concerns.
- **Roofer** — repairs shingles, flashing and ice-dam problems.
- **Electrician** — checks any wiring, outlets or panel that may have been exposed to water.

Questions to ask before you hire

- Are you licensed and insured in my area? Can you show proof?
- Do you offer emergency service, and how soon can someone arrive?
- Can I have a written estimate, and what could change the price?
- Will you give me photos and a written report for my records?

Local Hub tip: save a trusted plumber's and restoration company's numbers in your phone today — it beats a frantic search at 2 a.m.

Insurance tips

General suggestions to help you be organized. Policies differ widely, so always check your own policy wording and talk to your insurance provider or broker.

Before anything happens

- **Read your policy** so you know what types of water damage it mentions, and what it may not. Terms such as sewer backup, overland flooding and groundwater are often treated separately — ask your provider how they apply to you.
- **Ask about optional coverage** and deductibles, so there are no surprises later.
- **Keep a home inventory.** Walk through with your phone, filming each room and the contents. Store it in the cloud, not just on the phone.
- **Keep records** of maintenance, repairs and receipts, such as hose replacements or a sump pump battery backup.

After a leak

- **Contact your insurer promptly.** Many policies ask you to report a loss quickly and to take reasonable steps to prevent further damage.
- **Document everything:** photos and video, dates and times, what you noticed, and a list of damaged items with approximate value and age.
- **Keep damaged items** until your insurer says you can dispose of them, unless they are a hazard.
- **Save every receipt** for emergency repairs, drying, temporary accommodation and cleanup.
- **Write down** the claim number, the name of each person you speak to, and what was said.
- **Ask questions** if something is unclear — what is covered, what the deductible is, and what the next steps are.

Remember

This guide offers general information only and is not insurance, legal or professional advice. Coverage and requirements depend on your policy, your location and the circumstances of the loss.

Thank you for reading.

A little attention each month goes a long way. We hope you never need page 6 — but now you know where it is.

Local Hub · mylocal-hub.com